who practice these arts.’ The painters in their small cells would have sat on the floor, their drawing boards resting on their raised thighs, or placed slanting against the ground. Set around the artists would be just a few objects, of the very highest quality: twenty mussel or clam shells containing pigments, brushes made of kitten or squirrel hairs, a pot of water, and a pot of glue. The pigments were made of pounded gold or silver. Crushed minerals such as lapis lazuli mined in Afghanistan produced a vivid blue, cinnabar and copper salts a bright crimson, saffron from the crocuses in Kashmir, ground-up shells a chalky white, soot a deep black, and the urine of cows fed on mangoes a bright, arresting yellow.

Miniature painting was a long and laborious process, a moderately elaborate painting sometimes taking up to a month to finish. The paper would be first brushed with a light priming coat of white pigment then turned over and burnished to provide a smooth ground. The paintings were often a collaborative effort, in which one artist would draw the sketches and another would colour in the painting with a third artist reserved for painting faces. Mughal artists sometimes painted from life but usually worked from earlier sketches, with an emphasis on opulence of colour and fineness of details. Depth of colour was achieved by applying repeated layers of paint. ‘Sometimes actual jewels—rubies, emeralds, diamonds—or jewel-like beetle-wing-cases were attached to miniatures for special opulence.’ Hunched over their canvases, using a magnifying lens for fine detailing, the men would grow old, and would lose their eyesight, from the precision of the tiny works of art they created, worlds within worlds of fluttering movement, emotion, and splendour. Other artists would pay an even higher price for their years of precise and sustained effort. Daswant, untrained genius, and fragile of mind, would eventually commit suicide, perhaps overcome at the end by these dreams of spinning gold.

Alongside the painters were the calligraphers and scribes, who were especially revered not only for their artistic skill, but because they copied the sacred Koran and of whom it was said that ‘whoever writes “in the name of God the Merciful and Compassionate” in fine lettering will enter paradise’. The calligraphers worked with reed pens and their own special inks. Ambar Qalam (sweet pen) used a jealously guarded formulation which gave him a lustrous brownish-black ink, easily identifiable. And alongside the artists and illustrators were ateliers for jewellery, for textiles, for the ironsmiths and welders who wrought armour and arms, and for lapidary